conquerors-in-arms – that Abdur Rahim's children would call Man Singh 'Dadaji', grandfather.[36]

Akbar had not just brought home the mother of his eventual heir, he had also planted the seeds of profound transformation in the very nature of his court.

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Even if the facts are linked by chronology alone, it is interesting to note that soon after Akbar married his Rajput bride, Abul Fazl has him giving audience to a Brahmin petitioner. Hapa was his name, and he had come to complain about a group of eight villages called Athkanya, not far from Agra. The name 'eight maidens' suggests otherwise, but these villages contained a wicked lot, it seems, known for their 'insolence, robbery, manslaughter . . . and turbulence'.[37] They had killed Hapa's son and stolen all he owned. Akbar promised him justice.

It was delivered a day or two later, in the village of Paronkh. Some 400 men from the eight villages gathered here to resist Akbar's punitive force, which numbered about 200 soldiers and an equal number of elephants. As the smoke of battle filled the air, a disheartening sight filtered through it – far from storming the gates of Paronkh, many of Akbar's men were sheltering under trees and looking for other 'safe corner[s]' in which to hide. It was clear to him, as it must become clear to all people of ambition one day: if he wanted something done, he must do it himself.

Without wasting time reproving his reluctant soldiers, Akbar drove his elephant, Dalsingar,[38] into the narrow village lanes. All was confusion, 'a rain of sticks and stones and arrows'. Akbar thought he recognized one of his men by his yellow vest, wrestling on a roof, and charged towards him. Dalsingar's foot caught in a pit of grain; behind them, another elephant running at full speed wasn't expecting Dalsingar's sudden stop. It was an elephant pile-up!

Somehow, Akbar manoeuvred Dalsingar out of the pit. Most of the rebel villagers had retreated into a fortified compound; Akbar drove Dalsingar towards it, with Raja Bhagwant Das riding by his side.[39]

One of the enemy appeared before them, slashing at Dalsingar with his sword. It struck a heavy iron ring of a kind put around elephants' tusks 'for